

Figure 2: WikidPad

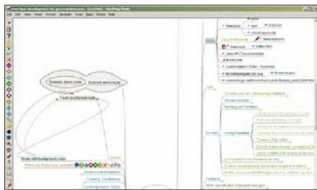


Figure 3: FreeMind screenshot



Figure 4: The PortableApps.com launcher

If you love to prepare mind maps to take notes during a training programme or while reading a book you will find *FreeMind* software quite useful. Actually, there are quite a few software tools available to prepare mind maps. I had evaluated some of them—covering both open source and commercial software (using evaluation copies). I finally selected *FreeMind*—not because it is freely

available but because I found it superior to other tools. Thanks to its simple layout and keyboard shortcuts, one can prepare mind maps using just the keyboard, without the need to juggle between the keyboard and mouse. That helps in quicker note taking. The software allows you to export the mind map documents to image

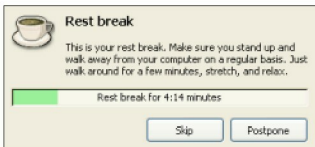


Figure 5: Workrave pop-up window reminding you to take a rest break

formats such as PNG. Thus you can share your mind maps with the world in the form of images. Browse <http://freemind.sourceforge.net> to know more about this product and to download its installer. Figure 3 shows how this software can be used.

Another tool that I use frequently is actually a software platform for running popular software tools from a pen drive. *Portableapps.com* is a site that provides this platform along with software tools that can be installed on a pen drive. You can then use this pen drive on any PC and launch your favourite applications from the former. Some examples of such portable applications include Firefox, Chrome, Skype, VLC Media Player, OpenOffice.org, etc. Figure 4 shows a screenshot of the launcher when you run the *StartPortableApps.exe* file from the pen drive. It lists all the software tools available on the pen drive. You can simply click on the one that you wish to run. It's that simple! Visit <http://portableapps.com/> to know more about this software solution and to download the base platform along with the portable versions of your favourite applications.

Finally, let me share one of my most favourite software tools, *workrave*. This is a program that assists in the recovery and prevention of Repetitive Strain Injury (RSI). The program frequently alerts you to take micro-pauses and rest breaks, and restricts you to your daily limit. Obviously, this frequency is what you pre-configure based on your preference. For example, I have configured the program to enable me to take 30-second micro-breaks after every 30 minutes of active keyboard/mouse usage and 5-minute rest breaks after every hour of active keyboard/mouse use. I have also set up six hours as the daily limit for me to spend working on the keyboard/mouse. I sometimes skip or postpone these breaks but generally tend to honour them. The tool also shows the statistics for metrics such as break prompts, breaks skipped, breaks postponed and even mouse button clicks over all the days in the last six months. Figure 5 shows the window that pops up reminding you about your rest break.

I hope you too will find some or all of these open source software tools useful in improving your personal productivity. I would love to hear your feedback. **END** 🐧

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